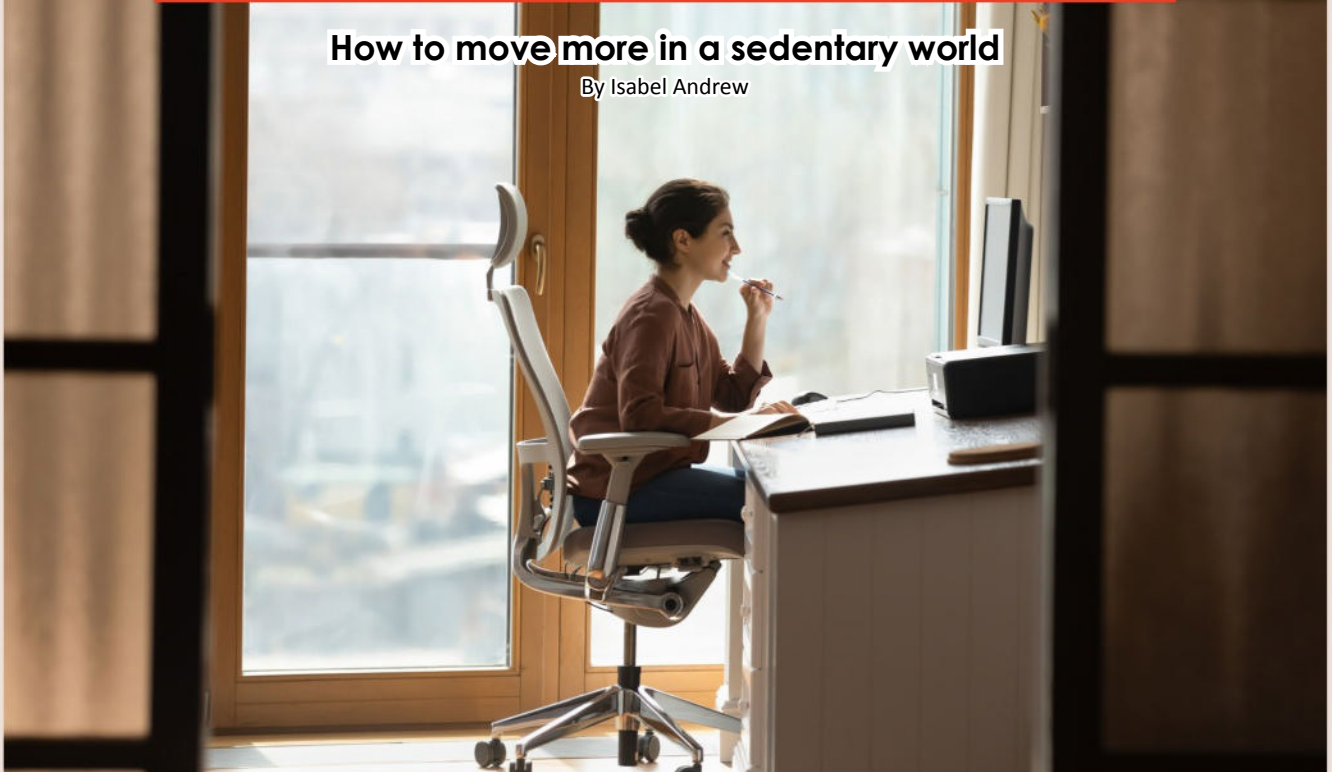


Sitting is the new smoking

How to move more in a sedentary world

By Isabel Andrew



Have you tried keeping track of how long in a day you are glued to a seat? If you start with sitting through traffic, at work, during lunch, we're talking around 5 hours or more – and that's just half the day!

Did you know that too much of that comfy chair can be a real health buzzkill? Research reports that sitting is now the new smoking. Still don't believe? Come on, let's take a stroll with science.

How long is too long to sit still?

The Malaysian Public Health Physicians Association defines sedentary behaviour as having minimal movement and a very low level of energy expenditure.

Although there aren't any clear criteria for what a sedentary lifestyle is, researchers have developed a few different

measurements to gauge it. One measure is the time an individual spends seated or reclining during their waking hours. Spending four to six waking hours sitting or lying down is considered sedentary.

Some researchers suggest that even those who adhere to the recommendation of the World Health Organisation — at least 150 minutes of moderate activity or 75 minutes of intense activity each week — can still be considered sedentary if they spend four to six hours sitting or reclining per day.

How bad is a sedentary lifestyle?

Our bodies crave movement. Being sedentary only makes our muscles lazy and our circulation sluggish, creating a toxin buildup that fuels chronic diseases. Here's more on what happens to your mind and body when you rest for too long on that bean bag:

→ LEGS AND GLUTES (BUM MUSCLES)

The muscles on our legs and glutes are important for stabilising us when we walk. Sitting for long durations can lead to weakening and wasting away of these muscles. This will lead to high risks of injuring ourselves from falls and straining during exercises.



→ WEIGHT

Moving your muscles helps digest fats and sugars which aids overall metabolic health. If you spend a lot of time sitting, digestion becomes inefficient and all those fats and sugars retain as fat in your body.



→ HIPS AND BACK

The hip flexor muscles are a group of muscles toward the front of the hip, connecting your pelvis and legs. These muscles help you move your leg and knee. Sitting for too long causes the hip flexor muscles to shorten, leading to possible problems with your hip joints.

Your back is also a victim of the sitting syndrome, especially if you're seated in a poor posture. A poor posture may cause poor spine health such as compression in the spine discs and premature degeneration of the bones.



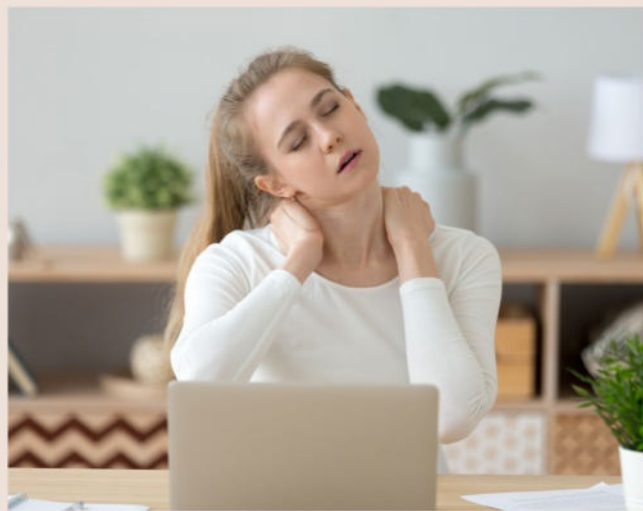
→ VARICOSE VEINS AND DEEP VEIN THROMBOSIS

Sitting for long periods causes blood to pool in your legs, leading to varicose veins or spider veins (a smaller version of varicose veins).

In severe and rare cases, it may also lead to blood clots forming deep vein thrombosis (DVT). If part of a blood clot in the vein breaks off, blood flow to other parts of the body could be cut off too. This includes your lungs, which can cause a pulmonary embolism and other fatal complications.

→ STIFF NECK AND SHOULDERS

It goes without saying that the longer you hunch over the computer keyboard, the more stiff and painful your neck and shoulder



→ CHRONIC HEALTH PROBLEMS

Studies have shown that people who are inactive and spend more time sitting or lying down, have an increased risk of chronic health problems, such as heart disease, stroke, diabetes and even some cancers.



➡ INFERTILITY

Studies also show that both women and men are susceptible to infertility by leading a sedentary lifestyle. This is because they are prone to becoming obese and overweight. They are also likely to develop diabetes and hypertension. All of these could result in poor-quality sperms and infrequent menses and ovulation periods.



➡ MENTAL HEALTH

Prolonged sitting has been associated with poor cognitive function too. Those who live a sedentary lifestyle are most likely deprived of exercise and fitness.

It has been proven that exercise is able to reduce the body's stress hormones like adrenaline and cortisol. It can also stimulate the production of mood-elevating hormones like endorphins.

Hence, inactivity doesn't only fog up the brain, wane off concentration and hinder creativity and productivity, it may also lead to depression and anxiety.



How to move more in a sedentary world

"How can I move around if I'm working at my desk all day?"
"I have exams coming up, I can't move away from my table!"

If these are your groans, wheel them away. It's not too late to get active, here are a few ways to do it:

- ➡ When you're tidying up or bringing the groceries into the kitchen, put items away in small trips rather than taking them all together.
- ➡ Walk around when you're on the phone, but be sure to be quiet and not distracting.
- ➡ Rather than sitting down to read, listen to audiobooks and walk around.
- ➡ Stand on public transport, or get off one stop early and walk to your destination.
- ➡ Stand up while you read emails or reports.
- ➡ Move your rubbish bin away from your desk so you have to get up to throw anything away.
- ➡ Set a timer or fitness tracker to alert you to take a break, stand up, walk around or grab some water every 30 minutes.



- ➡ Sit on a medicine ball, which engages your core muscles and prevents you from slouching.
- ➡ Take a short walk around your residential area after dinner.
- ➡ Use commercial breaks as a chance to refill the popcorn bowl or go for a toilet break.
- ➡ Get competitive with a sibling or friend. See who can do the most pushups or situps in five minutes.
- ➡ Plant a garden, and maybe spend some time talking to your plants for some good vibes.

Remember, every small move counts, even if it's a funky chicken dance or a little wiggle while waiting for the microwave ding! However, remember to give your feet some rest too, because balance is key. Now, walk the talk and share with a friend or two. ■

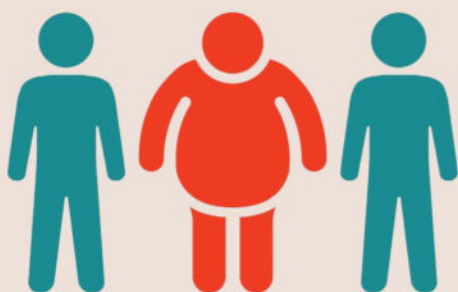
Sources: World Health Organization, Malaysian Public Health Physicians Association, National Health and Morbidity Survey (NHMS) 2022, Better Health Australia, Sanford Health, Mayo Clinic

HOW SEDENTARY ARE WE?

According to the National Health and Morbidity Survey (NHMS) 2022, which studied eating habits and physical activity among Malaysian teens (aged 13-17):

1 in 3

are overweight or obese



4 in 5

are physically inactive

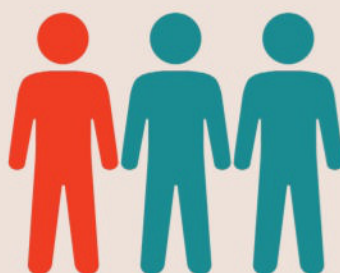
2 in 3

lead sedentary lifestyles



4 in 5

don't eat enough fruits and vegetables



1 in 3

drink soft drinks daily



1 in 10

eat fast food at least 3 days per week

